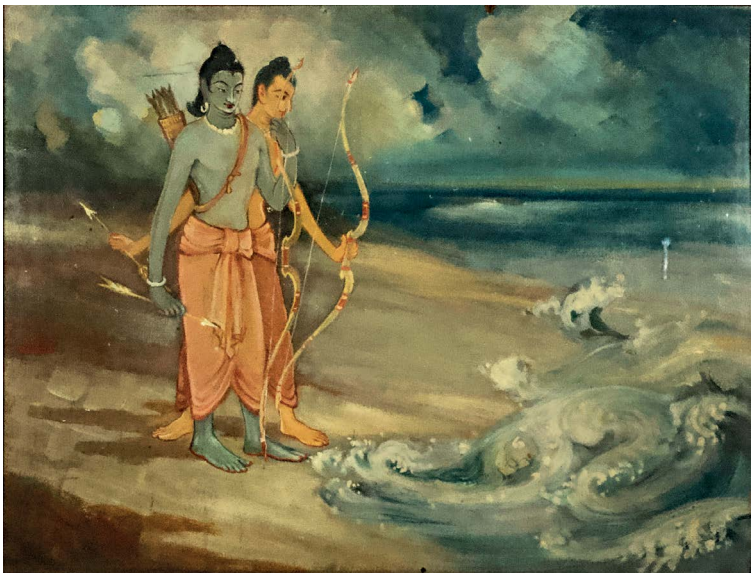
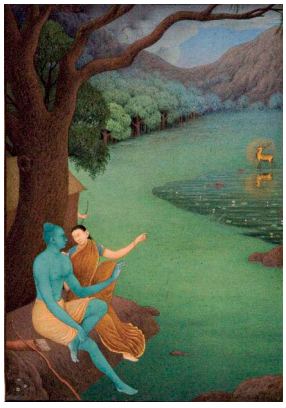




THE AGE OF RAM ((Clockwise from top) A panel showing Hanuman and Ravan; Kshitindranath Majumdar's 'Kaikeyi and Dashrath' (wash and tempera on paper); K. Venkatappa's 'Ram and Sita' (wash and tempera on paper); Upendra Maharathi's 'Sagar surrenders at the feet of Ram' (oil on canvas)





ART

Epic Tales

***Chitrakavyam Ramayanam*, an ongoing exhibition at NGMA Mumbai, features artistic interpretations of the Ramayana**

Fluid waves are dotted with delicate water droplets, their sensuous play of form and texture astonishingly rendered in stainless steel. The vastness of the sea is expressed through a deep reflection in the backdrop, while golden footprints gently tread the water's surface. This striking installation is 'Divine Walk' by Vibhor Sogani, an abstract interpretation of Lord Ram's mystical walk over the ocean to Lanka. It's part of *Chitrakavyam Ramayanam*, a wide-ranging exhibition at the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA) Mumbai, which merges traditional, modern and contemporary styles to convey the story of the Ramayana.

CHITRAKAVYAM RAMAYANAM
The exhibition is on at NGMA Mumbai till September 8

"*Chitrakavyam Ramayanam* acts as a connecting link between folk and traditional styles as well as modern and contemporary art forms, all narrating various aspects of Lord Ram's life," says Shruti Das, deputy curator, NGMA.

For the exhibition, NGMA has collaborated with numerous organisations and private collections to present 93 artworks across an array of mediums, including paintings, textiles, sculptures, shadow puppets and immersive installations. Many of these come from the NGMA collection itself, such as paintings by Nandalal Bose, Jamini Roy, Kshitindranath Majumdar and K. Venkatappa as well as prints by Chittaprosad Bhattacharya and Jyoti Bhatt. The exhibition spans various artistic traditions, from the Bengal School to contemporary styles. Traditional painting styles like Madhubani by artists Indrakala Devi and Bacho Devi make an appearance as does an evocative handwoven tapestry depicting Sita's abduction by Pappu Sonkar. The exhibition also includes artworks from other institutions such as DAG, IGNCA, MeMeraki, and India Post, the latter providing a collection of unique Ramayana-themed contemporary postage stamps.

One of the highlights is 'Kavad' by Charuvi Agrawal, which narrates the life of Hanuman with physical forms associated to his self-realisation journey. Kavad is an ancient folk-art of sharing stories in a pictorial manner through an enlarged shrine with folding shutters. The installation invites the user to go on an enchanted discovery of the Ram Setu, the sacred fruit, Ram's ring and Hanuman's jewellery. The idea is to let the viewer feel and interact with the real objects kept in the shelves in panels of the kavad. Agrawal's other works here are rather cutting-edge, such as the hologram installation, 'Hanuman's Journey: Verses Through Vision' and a virtual reality film, *The Legend of Hanuman*. Chitrakavyam also highlights many performing arts, including shadow puppetry and narrative art forms developed by indigenous tribal communities. ■

– Prachi Joshi